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Working Paper

# Africa's new International Relations: Bilateralism between Türkiye & Somalia

Understanding the foreign policy approaches behind Turkish-Somali cooperation

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## Acronyms & Abbreviations

**In alphabetical order**

| | |
|---|---|
| AFAD | Disaster and Emergency Management Presidency |
| AKP | Justice and Development Party |
| AMISOM | African Union Mission in Somalia |
| ATMIS | African Union Transition Mission in Somalia |
| AU | African Union |
| AUSSOM | African Union Support and Stabilization Mission in Somalia |
| Diyanet | Directorate of Religious Affairs |
| EU | European Union |
| İHH | Humanitarian Relief Foundation |
| MKE | Mechanical and Chemical Industry Corporation |
| MoU | Memorandum of Understanding |
| MRAP | Mine-Resistant Ambush Protected |
| NATO | North Atlantic Treaty Organization |
| NGO | Non-Governmental Organization |
| RSF | Rapid Support Forces |
| SAF(1) | Somali Armed Forces |
| SAF(2) | Sudanese Armed Forces |
| SNA | Somali National Army |
| TİKA | Turkish Cooperation and Coordination Agency |
| UAE | United Arab Emirates |
| UCAV | Unmanned Combat Aerial Vehicle |
| UN | United Nations |

# 1. Introduction

Over the past two decades, the architecture of Turkish foreign policy has undergone a fundamental reorientation, shifting from practices similar to traditional donors toward an assertive engagement across Africa, the Middle East and Central Asia (Özkan, 2010, p. 533ff.)(Siradag, 2025, p. 19-22). At the epicenter of this shift sits the Federal Republic of Somalia. The ruling Justice and Development Party (AKP) under Recep Tayyip Erdoğan has articulated a foreign policy that merges Islamic solidarity, military support, and economic development in the country (Altunişik, 2022, pp. 1-5)(Mamouni, 2025, p. 1f.). By positioning itself as an authentic, non-colonial protector of Muslim populations, Ankara has leveraged its intervention in Somalia to improve its global status, and to demonstrate its capacity to deliver tangible state-building solutions (Cannon, 2016, pp. 99ff.)(Altunişik, 2022, p. 4f.).

This engagement was catalyzed in August 2011, when then-Prime Minister Erdoğan led a delegation to Mogadishu, becoming the first non-African head of state to visit the capital in nearly two decades (Wasuge, 2016, p. 13). What began as a high-visibility emergency relief campaign rapidly evolved into an institutionalized partnership encompassing infrastructure development, economic concessions, educational mobility, and security cooperation (Siradag, 2016, p. 92f.)(Ahmed, 2025, pp. 1-4). Between 2011 and 2021, Turkish state agencies and faith-based Non-Government Organizations (NGO)'s disbursed over $1 billion in technical and humanitarian assistance (Altunişik, 2022, p. 10). Commercial air links were restored via Turkish Airlines in 2012, while Turkish private conglomerates secured long-term, non-competitively tendered management concessions across Somalia. Simultaneously, Ankara established (Figure 1: Camp TURKSOM) in 2017, its largest overseas military training facility to date, to equip the Somali National Army (SNA)[1] and deployed advanced defense hardware, including Mine-Resistant Ambush Protected (MRAP) vehicles and (Figure 3: Bayraktar TB2) armed drones (Burak and Tutek, 2024, p. 21f.)(Siradag, 2025, p. 28f.) to the conflict-affected region.

To analyze this partnership, with its extensive projects, and the political reasoning behind it, the paper proposes the following central research question: What defines the foreign policy rationales underpinning Turkish-Somali cooperation, what drives Türkiye's strategy in the Horn of Africa, and how do Somali political realities shape this relationship? By systematically analyzing both

[1]The SNA are the ground forces part of the Somali Armed Forces (SAF)(1).

Ankara's imperatives and Mogadishu's statecraft, this paper offers a two-sided account of a modern South-South security and development relationship. The goal is to understand the foreign policy approaches behind Turkish-Somali cooperation, both from the Turkish and Somali perspective.

## 2. Framework & Methodology

The paper aims to answer these questions with a qualitative dual foreign policy analysis. What this paper will not do is to re-analyze the well-documented and explored Turkish aid and development model and how it established the Turkish state as a clear "Middle Power" (Mamouni, 2025) over the last decade, not only in Somalia and the Horn of Africa, but across multiple countries in the Northern half of Africa, as well as in certain Middle Eastern and Central Asian countries. It utilizes a conglomeration of various theoretical frameworks for this analysis.

Firstly the paper makes use of Bayart (2000)'s strategies of extraversion & active dependency. Bayart (2000) rejects the artificial dichotomy between internal and external spheres, conceptualizing Africa's insertion into the global political economy as organic, continuous, and co-constitutive. External interventions or global norms (such as democracy or structural adjustment) are routinely re-appropriated by local elites as instruments of governance and political survival (Bayart, 2000, pp. 218f., 222ff.). Further, Callaghy, Kassimir, and Latham (2001) on transboundary formations. They highlight how authority, order, and governance in Africa are produced across varied juridical/non-juridical and state/non-state networks, ranging from international financial institutions to multinational corporations or informal trading networks (Callaghy, Kassimir, and Latham, 2001, pp. 12, 15f.).

In addition, Abrahamsen (2017)'s assemblage methodology, she proposes examining Africa as a space where global and local forces are contingently fitted together from the ground up and African security dynamics reflect global transformations in governance, risk, and capital. Also, Englebert and Dunn (2013), as they detail how African international relations have undergone a significant privatization, manifested in the concept of the "shadow state", where rulers construct personal networks behind formal legal statehood, relying on informal markets, foreign concessionaires, private security companies, and international NGOs to maintain rule (Englebert and Dunn, 2013, p. 366ff.).

As well as Hönke, Cezne, and Yang (2024), critiquing monolithic concepts of global governance,

proposing that large infrastructure sites (e.g. ports, railways, mines) are conceptualized as frontier zones, where expanding political-economic rationales meet, are negotiated, and contested. They demonstrate how African agency across multiple scales (e.g. elites, bureaucrats, civil society, local communities) re-appropriates, resists, and transforms practices, demonstrating that South-South relations are co-produced rather than top-down model exports (Hönke, Cezne, and Yang, 2024, pp. 5, 12, 38f.). Lastly to be mentioned is Tieku (2022), calling for an "offensive" knowledge production agenda, grounded in epistemic freedom. He emphasizes a relational ontology (viewing actors as inherently social and embedded in regional/collective structures). It thus also becomes imperative to think from which viewpoint knowledge was produced and collected for this project.

Drawing from these theoretical frameworks, the guiding query slightly transforms. Is Somalia to be viewed as a testing ground for Turkish military tactics and hardware, its geostrategic and economic influence, as well as a tool for its international goals? In other words is Somalia a docile state held alive by Turkish plans, or is it more than that? Is Somalia an actual strategic partner with its own epistemic agency and foreign agenda in this bilateral relationship, potentially sitting eye to eye with Türkiye? Can Somalia's actions in this relationship be understood through the concepts of active dependency, transboundary formations and global assemblage?

## 3. Case Studies

To understand the modern international relation between Türkiye and Somalia the paper will investigate the foreign agency of both countries, as well as major joint projects that define this bilateral relationship under the just described parameters, starting with Türkiye and then moving on to Somalia.

### 3.1 Türkiye's Agency

Türkiye's engagement with Somalia, or Africa in general is, according to its own government, a core foreign policy commitment. The Ministry of Foreign Affairs explicitly states that "developing our relations and cooperation with the African Continent is one of the basic principles of our multi-dimensional foreign policy" (Republic of Türkiye Ministry of Foreign Affairs, 2022, para. 1). This engagement traces back to 1998, when Ankara launched its Africa Initiative Policy, gaining institutional traction when Türkiye became an African Union (AU) observer in 2005 and a strategic partner in 2008. The policy is framed not as charity but as a mutual project. Ankara pursues

relations "on the basis of equal partnership and mutual benefit" (Republic of Türkiye Ministry of Foreign Affairs, 2022, para. 6), sharing what it describes as its "historical experience, social, political and cultural accumulation" (Republic of Türkiye Ministry of Foreign Affairs, 2022, para. 3) with African states. The economic results are measurable, total trade with Africa rose from $5.4 billion in 2003 to $34.5 billion in 2021, underpinned by an expanding embassy network, Turkish Airlines connectivity, TİKA development offices, and over 15,000 African student scholarships since 1992. Somalia sits squarely within this broader continental strategy, representing its most intensive bilateral application (Republic of Türkiye Ministry of Foreign Affairs, 2022, para. 9-14).

Regarding Somalia, following decades of stymied interventions, high security costs, and the perception of Somalia as too difficult, traditional donors and international agencies largely withdrew to compounds or managed operations remotely from Nairobi, Kenya during the 2000's and 2010's (Cannon, 2016, p. 100)(Wasuge, 2016, p. 5)(Siradag, 2016, p. 90). Their interventions were often bogged down by bureaucratic delays, abstract governance seminars, and strict political conditionality (Wasuge, 2016, p. 20f.). China or other southern donors generally avoided deep state-building interventions in high-risk, non-industrialized environments like Somalia at that time, lacking stable legal guarantees or immediate large-scale commodity returns (Mamouni, 2025, pp. 4, 11). Türkiye entered Somalia at the height of a famine in 2011, when international expectations were low, meaning any tangible success yielded outsized diplomatic returns. By combining humanitarian aid, physical infrastructure (e.g. roads, hospitals, schools), military training to combat non-state actors across the nation, and private enterprise into a single integrated model, Ankara created a self-reinforcing footprint that overcame volatile periods. As Altunişik (2022) and Senyurt and Taskin (2024) detail, Türkiye under the ruling AKP framed its involvement through Humanitarian Diplomacy, this discourse merged Islamic solidarity with an enterprising foreign policy that contrasted "benevolent" Turkish interventions against Western "colonialism" or indifference (Altunişik, 2022, p. 11f.)(Senyurt and Taskin, 2024, p. 28f.). Mobilizing state institutions alongside faith-based NGOs and charities (e.g., Kızılay, İHH) helped the AKP reinforce its domestic identity, build "Islamic social capital", and broaden its domestic support base (Altunişik, 2022, p. 7).

Türkiye's engagement has also seen defense & security projection. In 2017 Ankara opened the mentioned (Figure 1: Camp TURKSOM) in Mogadishu, where more than 25000 Somali soldiers have been trained by Turkish personnel as of 2026 (Inside Somalia, 2026, para. 1f.). Further-

more, Somalia has served as an operational arena for Turkish defense equipment, notably (Figure 3: Bayraktar TB2) drones and modern armed vehicles types, deployed in counter-insurgency operations against Al-Shabaab (Siradag, 2025, pp. 28)(Burak and Tutek, 2024, pp. 21). Furthermore, agreements signed in 2024-2025 grant Türkiye exclusive offshore and onshore hydrocarbon exploration rights (covering 16,000 km$^2$), positioning Ankara near the Bab el-Mandeb Strait to secure Red Sea trade routes and compete against Gulf rivals like the United Arab Emirates (UAE)(Mamouni, 2025, p. 11)(Abdulle and Gurpinar, 2019, p. 62).

To add, is Somalia profit-generating for Türkiye? From an economy perspective, yes. Somalia serves as a gateway for Turkish businesses, it establishes new export markets for construction materials, consumer goods, medical equipment, and services. Türkiye's increasingly export-driven economic strategy found an eager, non-industrialized market in Somalia. Turkish exports to Somalia rose from under $5 million in 2009-2010 to over $270–$355 million annually by 2020-2021, whereas Somali exports to Türkiye remained under $5 million (Abdulle, 2022, p. 71ff.). This asymmetry provides Türkiye with a continuous trade surplus. Further, Somali federal authorities awarded Turkish conglomerates long-term management contracts over some of Mogadishu's primary revenue engines. Albayrak Group operates the Port of Mogadishu under a 20-year concession, retaining 45% of gross revenues (Wasuge, 2016, pp. 18, 26)(Siradag, 2016, p. 99). Favori LLC manages Aden Adde International Airport under a 20-year build-operate-transfer contract, collecting aviation, passenger, and ground-handling fees (Siradag, 2016, p. 99). Turkish Airlines was the first major international carrier to resume direct flights to Mogadishu in 2012, operating a highly profitable monopoly with ticket prices among the highest per-mile globally (Wasuge, 2016, pp. 6, 26)(Burak and Tutek, 2024, p. 15). Moreover, direct agreements signed in 2024 and 2025 granted Türkiye exclusive on- and offshore hydrocarbon exploration and production rights,covering 16,000 km$^2$, with the Turkish vessel Oruç Reis conducting 3D seismic surveys off the Somali coast (Mamouni, 2025, p. 11). Engagements in Somalia also provide an operational stage for Türkiye's expanding defense industry. As mentioned Somalia serves as a direct market for Turkish defense exports, including various vehicle types, small arms, and drones used in counter-insurgency operations. In addition, in April 2024, the two countries signed a maritime security agreement under which Türkiye would provide equipment and training for the Somali navy in exchange for 30% of revenues from Somalia's exclusive economic zone (Walker, 2024).

It can also be argued that Ankara selected Somalia precisely because its "failed" or "fragile" status.

Thus the country offered high risk but high returns in international prestige and political capital (Cannon, 2016, p. 98ff.). A driving objective behind engaging in Somalia can be understood as a pursuit of international political capital and global recognition. By stepping into a volatile environment where traditional powers and international organizations had repeatedly struggled, Türkiye aimed to demonstrate its capacity as a rising leader of the Global South. Also, Somalia's geographic location at the edge of the Bab el-Mandeb Strait, the Gulf of Aden, and critical Red Sea trade routes gives it strategic importance. Establishing a strong presence in Mogadishu and its surrounding areas allows Ankara to project power across the Indian Ocean, protect maritime trade corridors, and counterbalance regional competitors such as the UAE, Saudi Arabia, and neighbours like Ethiopia or Kenya. To add, rather than focusing primarily on just governance or democratic guidelines, Türkiye delivered visible infrastructure. Paved tarmac roads, modern street lighting, clean water wells, a state-of-the-art Recep Tayyip Erdoğan Training and Research Hospital, a new international airport terminal, as well as various vocational schools (Senyurt and Taskin, 2024, p. 30). So visible was this footprint that Türkiye was dubbed "the McDonald's of Mogadishu", due to the omnipresence of Turkish flags across the capital of Somalia (Cannon, 2016, p. 100).

Another core element of Türkiye's agency in Somalia rests on its shared Islamic identity and deliberate religious and cultural diplomacy. The AKP government actively frames its engagement around shared Sunni Muslim heritage, historical ties to the Ottoman Empire, and the Islamic obligation of "Zakat" and brotherhood (Altunişik, 2022, pp. 4f, 7, 9). Through the Turkish Cooperation and Coordination Agency (TİKA), Türkiye has invested in restoring historic, sometimes Ottoman-Era, mosques, ports, and castles in coastal cities like Berbera and Zeila, and to thus reinforce historical legitimacy (Siradag, 2016, p. 96f.). Türkiye's Directorate of Religious Affairs (Diyanet) and the state-backed Turkish Religious Foundation (Türkiye Diyanet Vakfı) further established a religious services counsellor's office in Mogadishu in 2014 (Senyurt and Taskin, 2024, p. 33). The Diyanet provides direct humanitarian aid, builds mosques, supports local Quranic schools, and sponsors hundreds of Somali students to undertake higher religious and theological studies in Turkish universities (Senyurt and Taskin, 2024, p. 33f.). Education represents one of Türkiye's primary agency vectors. Following the 2016 coup attempt in Türkiye, Ankara established the state-run Maarif Foundation to assume control over international schools and build new educational institutions. In Somalia, Maarif operates multiple primary and secondary schools and dormitories (Altunişik, 2022, pp. 7, 14). Additionally, faith-based Turkish NGOs, such as İHH

(Humanitarian Relief Foundation), Yardım Eli, and Deniz Feneri, constructed major facilities, including the Anadolu Education Center, the largest orphanage in Somalia, vocational health schools, and agricultural training colleges (Senyurt and Taskin, 2024, p. 32). Further building on the blend of infrastructure and faith, Türkiye constructed an enormous Ottoman-style mosque capable of holding 2,000 worshippers at the rebuilt Digfer Hospital complex, flying in specialized Turkish artists to complete the interior artwork (Wasuge, 2016, p. 27). Türkiye also instituted one of the largest foreign scholarship programs for Somali youth through university networks. Thousands of Somali teenagers and university students received full scholarships to study in Türkiye across disciplines like engineering, medicine, international relations, and theology, creating a new Turkish-educated Somali administrative and technical elite (Ahmed, 2025, p. 5). Funding mosque construction and providing official religious education through the Diyanet gives Ankara a platform to promote an authentic, state-integrated vision of Islam. This directly challenges the ideological monopoly of insurgent groups like Al-Shabaab, who view Türkiye's state-building model as a direct threat to their religious authority and have repeatedly targeted Turkish embassy staff, military personnel, and engineering crews (Burak and Tutek, 2024, p. 14f.).

Türkiye's engagement in Somalia is executed through precise institutional architecture. At the core of this framework sits a diplomatic and development apparatus led by the Ministry of Foreign Affairs and TİKA, which coordinates technical, medical, and infrastructural projects without traditional Western donor conditionality. This development umbrella is supported by emergency relief entities such as the Disaster and Emergency Management Presidency (AFAD) and the Turkish Red Crescent (Kızılay), alongside logistical connectivity provided by companies like Turkish Airlines, which reconnected Mogadishu to global transit routes as well as defense deals of various kinds, establishing a permanent Turkish presence in the nation (Altunişik, 2022, pp. 2, 7). Ankara explicitly frames its role as a non-colonizing "virtuous power", without historical imperial baggage (Mamouni, 2025, p. 5). By acting unilaterally and coordinating its state and non-state institutions, Türkiye bypassed multilateral bottlenecks to execute its projects directly. In a nutshell, a simplified version of Turkish engagement in Somalia looks like this (Figure 2: Turkish Cycle of Engagement in Somalia).

### 3.2 Somalia's Agency

Regarding Somalia, why go with Türkiye as a central partner over more established, traditional ones or other, potentially closer (both geographically and culturally) ones in the region. What

makes the Turkish model attractive for the Somali state in the long term during a time in which multiple foreign powers and international interventions have been terminated, switched out or expelled by governments throughout the continent? The argument: Somali leaders have strategically used their relationship with Türkiye as an extraverted balancing mechanism to offset the overbearing influence of immediate regional competitors and Gulf State influences. By having a close partnership with Ankara, a major non-neighbouring North Atlantic Treaty Organization (NATO) member without a colonial history in the Horn of Africa, Mogadishu has gained crucial military, diplomatic, and economic leverage.

Historically, international organizations filtered much of their Horn of Africa security strategy through Addis Ababa or Nairobi, leaving Somali federal authorities in a subordinate security position relative to Ethiopia or Kenya. As Abdulle and Gurpinar (2019) highlight, these systems created semi-failed strategies largely based on non-Somali perspectives, whereas cultivating ties with Türkiye allowed Somalia to introduce an alternative, powerful ally into local political dynamics (Abdulle and Gurpinar, 2019, p. 66f.). Plus, Somali officials frequently contrast Türkiye's rapid implementation to experiences with Western bureaucratic processes. Traditional donors often spent years conducting feasibility assessments and routing funds through international channels, which consumed significant administrative overhead, whereas Turkish actors delivered faster physical projects at scale (Wasuge, 2016, pp. 20f., 28). Also, Somali leaders explicitly noted that while previous development relied on foreign NGO intermediaries and imposed heavy political conditionality, Turkish aid workers, engineers, and doctors lived alongside Somalis, trained local personnel directly, and introduced a collaborative work culture (Wasuge, 2016, p. 5f., 8)(Senyurt and Taskin, 2024, p. 28f.).

Furthermore, when Ethiopia signed a Memorandum of Understanding (MoU) with the breakaway region of Somaliland in January 2024 to secure sea access in exchange for state recognition, the Somali Federal Government responded by signing a landmark 10-year Defense and Economic Cooperation Agreement with Türkiye in February 2024. Under this deal, Türkiye agreed to help rebuild, equip, and train the Somali Navy to protect Somalia's 3,300 km coastline against external threats and illegal fishing (Ahmed, 2025, p. 4f.). Somali President Hassan Sheikh Mohamud then went on to utilize Turkish mediation to broker the "Ankara Declaration" in December 2024 (Mamouni, 2025, p. 4)(Siradag, 2025, p. 24ff.). This agreement affirmed Ethiopia's full recognition of Somalia's territorial integrity while granting Ethiopia commercial access to Somali ports

under international law, effectively neutralizing Addis Ababa's unilateral deal with Somaliland. Applying Bayart (2000)'s concept of extraversion here shows that Somali political actors actively managed Turkish involvement to serve internal political goals for instance.

The Horn of Africa has long been a theater for Middle Eastern geopolitical competition as well. Somali federal leaders actively leveraged Türkiye to resist Emirati efforts to control key Somali assets and bypass the central government. The Somali government replaced the UAE-based firm SKA[2] at Aden Adde International Airport with the above mentioed Turkish firm Favori LLC. These moves reflected a deliberate effort by Mogadishu to push back against Gulf financial monopolies in the area. The UAE responded by establishing direct port concessions and military ties with regional administrations in Somaliland and Puntland[3] (Altunişik, 2022, p. 12)(Abdulle and Gurpinar, 2019, p. 61). This regional rivalry led to the current status quo of Abu Dhabi backing breakaway entities, while Mogadishu relies on Turkish state-building aid to preserve national unity. Per Wasuge (2016), the initial impetus did not originate solely in Ankara, former Somali President Sheikh Sharif Sheikh Ahmed made three official visits to Turkey prior to 2011 to actively persuade Turkish leadership to adopt an strong role in Somalia (Wasuge, 2016, pp. 11-15). By bringing in a major non-Western NATO member, Somali leaders deliberately used Türkiye to counterbalance the overbearing influence of other states in the region, thereby acquiring greater diplomatic space and domestic maneuverability.

However, Somalia clearly lacks agency in other metrics. In e.g. trade and formal economics, the relationship remains heavily asymmetrical. Turkish exports to Somalia increased starkly from $3.5 million in 2009 to up to $355 million by 2021, whereas Somali exports to Türkiye slacked and remained negligible, under $8 million, creating a significant trade deficit (Abdulle, 2022, p. 68)(O. Hassan, Ndalila, and Abdulrahman, 2023, p. 139f.)(S. M. Hassan, 2022, pp. 58-61). This is largely due to security instability, a lack of sovereign industrial capacity, and a narrow export base centered on livestock and raw materials from Somalia's point of view (S. M. Hassan, 2022, p. 59f.). Furthermore, as mentioned, key state assets have been ceded to Turkish management under highly unequal terms.

Yet, Somali officials do not perceive themselves as subjects of Turkish imperialism (Abdulle, 2022, p. 75)(Ahmed, 2025, p. 4f.). By using Turkish technical know-how to rebuild state institutions,

[2]The acronym does not stand for anything.

[3]These two regions are the most prominent breakaway states within the official borders of Somalia.

professionally train the SAF(1), reclaim territorial waters from illegal fishing, and secure maritime defense deals, Somalia actively employs Türkiye as a partner to reconstruct its empirical statehood and exit international isolation. Somali officials frequently contrasted this direct, fast-tracked bilateral aid against other donor mechanisms (like by the United Nations (UN) or European Union (EU)), that routed funds through heavy political conditionalities (Wasuge, 2016, pp. 20f., 28). By receiving direct Turkish budget assistance, infrastructure development, and arms shipments, Somali leaders gained immediate operational capacity and domestic political survival tools without subjecting themselves to any governance mandates.

Somali leaders have also used Türkiye to break their dependence on neighboring states, which deploy(ed) their own troops under various AU Missions in Somalia (Abdulle and Gurpinar, 2019, pp. 56, 68).[4] Former Somali President Sheikh Sharif Sheikh Ahmed actively lobbied Ankara to adopt a protective role in Somalia (Wasuge, 2016, p. 5f.). By securing Turkish military training and advanced hardware Somalia developed specialized counter-insurgency capabilities that operate directly under federal command, rather than under regional or foreign-led peacekeeping umbrellas. In line with Englebert and Dunn (2013)'s ideas, this system further utilized direct Turkish budgetary support to maintain domestic patronage networks, fund security apparatuses, and preserve political control in Mogadishu. Turkish military training and drones provided to the federal government present it with crucial military leverage against Al-Shabaab or other political opposition.

Moreover, Rather than a static bilateral relationship, Turkish-Somali cooperation functions as a contested transboundary formation. Infrastructure sites across Mogadishu can act as frontier zones where global capital meets local contestation. Turkish state-building has for example not proceeded unhindered. Local port workers staged strikes against Albayrak's takeover, domestic political opposition petitioned against Turkish arms shipments during election delays, and Al-Shabaab has repeatedly targeted Turkish engineers, embassy staff, and military facilities (Altunişik, 2022, p. 11)(Cannon, 2016, p. 101f.). The security architecture in Mogadishu, combining Turkish military advisors, SAF(1) troops, ATMIS/AUSSOM/AMISOM peacekeepers and local workers also demonstrates Abrahamsen (2017)'s thesis that African security is a contingent assemblage of global, national, and local authority, rather than simple state control.

[4]For instance: The African Union Mission in Somalia (AMISOM) African Union Transition Mission in Somalia (ATMIS) and currently active African Union Support and Stabilization Mission in Somalia (AUSSOM).

For Somali state elites, partnering with Türkiye has served as a strategy of extraversion. By inviting Ankara's military, commercial, and diplomatic power, Somali leaders successfully created a counterweight to Ethiopian dominance, resisted Emirati-backed fragmentation, and built a more autonomous national army and revenue base, while reconstructing their state apparatus and combating domestic insurgencies. While Türkiye undoubtedly derives substantial geostrategic goals and commercial benefits from its footprint in the country, Somalia operates as an active partner.

### 3.3 Ankara's Way: Equal, Just & Universal?

Beyond Somalia, Türkiye is especially dominant in other North African nations, i.e., Egypt, which formalized a large defense deal in early 2026 (Al Defaiya, 2026, para. 6). Reached between the Mechanical and Chemical Industry Corporation (MKE) of Türkiye and the Egyptian Defense Ministry, includes the export of various Turkish defense designs, along with plans to build a large ammunition factory in Egpyt.

The most visible dimension of the Turkish security footprint beyond Somalia are Unmanned Combat Aerial Vehicle (UCAV), in other words drones, exports. Turkish defense company Baykar leads in UCAV capabilities and has positioned the nation as the world's leading exporter of armed UCAV (Baykar, 2014). African nations constitute a growing market for the company.[5]

Beyond hardware in the defense industry Turkish construction companies are also active across Africa through various land and infrastructure projects. TİKA's main areas of cooperation include agriculture, health, education, water and sanitation, vocational training, and institutional-capacity development. Türkiye provides direct economic support through the Eximbank and the ministry of economy as well. Its approach emphasizes working together with respective on-site workforces rather than for them, meaning training local personnel or improving capacity on site (Özkan as in Bergamaschi, Moore, and Tickner, 2017, p. 66ff.).

Nonetheless, this footprint is not without controversy. More Turkish weaponry and equipment in Africa means it can fall in various hands, such as in Sudan's ongoing Civil War, Turkish-made weapons have reached both the state-controlled Sudanese Armed Forces (SAF)(2) and the rival Rapid Support Forces (RSF) (Al Jazeera, 2026, para. 14ff.). Inspite of such concerns, the appeal

[5]Beyond Somalia, e.g. Morocco or Libya have also incorporated such Turkish drones into their armed forces (Reuters, 2021, para. 6f.).

of Türkiye lies in its unique position. The drones by themselves have become political symbols as well. Türkiye thus transforms African security settings not through overwhelming force or predatory extraction, but through a patient accumulation of deliveries and relationships that gradually reorient several states in Africa toward Ankara as an alternative partner or potential foe.

However, Trukish policymakers exhibit a distinct geographical self-awareness. Rather than seeking universal or unconstrained global power projection, Türkiye's foreign policy is geographically and culturally bounded. The structural architecture of Turkish foreign policy under the AKP relies fundamentally on an ideational framework of shared Sunni Islamic identity and perceived cultural proximity, reverberarting deep with various Islamic-oriented nations, but not beyond that realm. Ankara operates primarily within this specific historical, faith-based diplomacy, where social legitimacy can be readily mobilized. Turkish policymakers are acutely aware of these spatial boundaries and do not intend to overextend into regions where they lack these foundational assets, recognizing that their rhetoric depends on local cultural resonance (Altunişik, 2022, p. 8f.).

Moreover, Despite its empirical and diplomatic visibility in the Horn of Africa, Türkiye's foreign policy strategy carries structural vulnerabilities. The Turkish economy operates under resource constraints. Sustained funding for TİKA projects or university scholarship programs remains directly exposed to domestic macroeconomic developments, specifically high inflation or foreign debt pressures (Mamouni, 2025, p. 11)(Senyurt and Taskin, 2024, p. 34). During domestic economic downturns, Ankara risks being unable to maintain its financial commitments at scale, exposing the gap between its global ambitions and material capacities. To add, as Türkiye's security footprint expands through sales or military agreements, it faces the persistent threat of becoming entangled in regional rivalries. For instance, following Ethiopia's controversial 2024 MoU with Somaliland for maritime access, Türkiye was forced into a delicate balancing act between Ethiopia and Somalia, two important defense customers. While, as explored, Ankara solved this through the "Ankara Declaration", it goes to show that selling to rivals can have lasting, potentially negative, effects (Mamouni, 2025, p. 4)(Siradag, 2025, p. 24ff.).

## 4. Conclusion

To summarize, when viewed predominantely through Bayart (2000) alongside Callaghy, Kassimir, and Latham (2001) and Abrahamsen (2017), Somali state elites can be understood as active archi-

tects of their international relations, while being aware of local melting pots of power, accepting less direct control in the process. Somali leaders actively lobbied for Turkish intervention before 2011 to break out of international isolation, secure direct budgetary support for domestic patronage networks, and continue on to build a semi-independent national army.

Furthermore, Mogadishu purposefully deployed Turkish naval backing and drone technology to counterbalance overbearing regional neighbours and the UAE's influence which helped it bypass federal authority through sub-state port deals, this is semi-successful as the UAE still has influence in the nation and Ethiopian troops are still active in Somalia through the current AUSSOM mission. The security architecture in Mogadishu, combining Turkish military advisors, SNA troops, AUSSOM peacekeepers, and private contractors, however demonstrates Abrahamsen (2017)'s points, that African security is a contingent assemblage of global, national, and privatized authority rather than simple state control.

As such Somalia is neither merely a passive testing ground for the Turkish military and the nation's geostrategic ambitions, nor is it a fully equal partner exercising unconstrained epistemic autonomy. The structural trade deficit, where Turkish exports dominate the Somali market, reflects persistent economic asymmetries. The Turkish-Somali relationship is best conceptualised as a co-produced transboundary security and economic formation. It represents an intersection where Turkish power-projection meets active Somali extraversion. Within this shared space, both actors leverage shared ideational markers to negotiate their respective geopolitical survival, security imperatives, and international standing.

The core problem described by Tieku (2022) also persists, even in this paper. Only 4 from the 28 sources, articles and papers used for this project were by Somali authors, in contrast to the 15 by Turkish authors. Turkish knowledge production far outweights its Somali counterpart in this respect. While the reasons behind this are diverse (e.g. lack of funding, access to higher education, or publicity in journals), the results are the same and epistemic knowledge for this paper, as well as many other texts regarding the topic, is far from equally distributed.

# Appendix




Figure 1: TURKSOM. Loc.: 1°59'46.99"N 45°16'13.02"E (Google Earth) Blue Lines for Scale Ref.

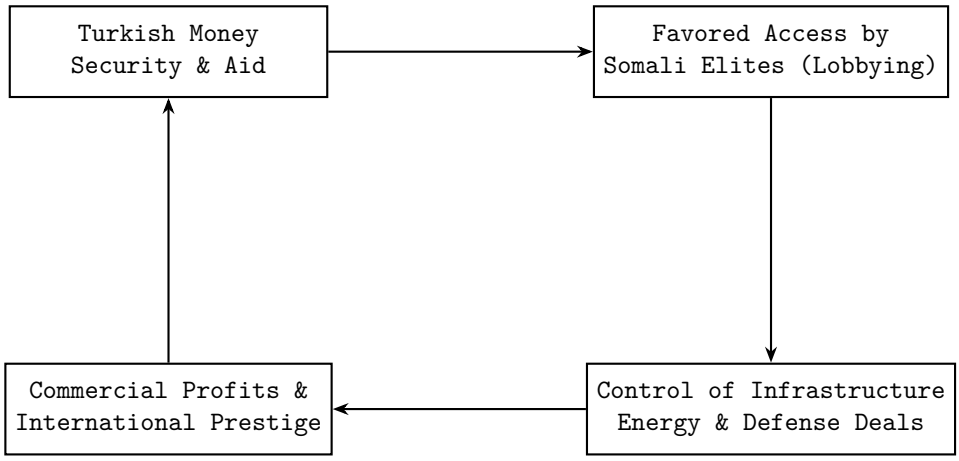



Figure 2: Turkish Cycle of Engagement in Somalia (Own Visualisation)




Figure 3: Bayraktar TB2 (Baykar, 2014)

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